PDF-Stift – Quick Guide

Quick guide for the Windows and Linux apps · October 2026

PDF-Stift is a program for reading, annotating and organizing PDF files such as lecture slides, papers and scans. You can also keep notebooks and design presentations or import them from PowerPoint. This quick guide shows what is available and where to find it. Menu and button names are given as they appear in the English interface; the language can be switched under Settings → Language. This edition runs entirely on your PC. It needs no account and no server, and your PDFs stay as ordinary files in a folder on your computer.

The Window

At the very top are the tabs of the open documents. Next to them on the right are the **Pages**, **Comments**, **Tools** and **Presentation** buttons, the switch between light and dark design, and the "Saved" indicator.

Below them is the ribbon with the tabs File, Start, Insert, Drawing, Pages, Slide show, View and Help – arranged as in office programs. Double-clicking a tab or pressing Ctrl + F1 collapses and expands the ribbon. In the Windows app, Alt shows the classic menu bar with every command.

Under the ribbon are the pen bar (favorite pens, undo, zoom) and the tool bar (tools, colors and stroke widths) with the toolbar. Drag any bar by its grip on the left to any edge of the window. **View → Default layout** puts everything back; **View → Compact (ribbon only)** hides the tool bar.

Opening Files and the Library

The library has three areas: **My PDFs**, **Notebook** and **Presentations**. Tapping a document opens it in its own tab.

- Open a PDF: tap it in the library or press Ctrl + O.
- Library folder: your PDFs are ordinary files in **Documents\PDF-Stift**. Open it with Help → Open library folder; change it with Help → Change library folder (or Settings → Library).
- Drag files in from Explorer – Word, PowerPoint and Excel files too; they become PDFs PC
- Word and PowerPoint files are converted with the bundled LibreOffice – no internet needed (Windows app; on Linux with LibreOffice installed).
- Right-click in Explorer → "Open in PDF-Stift" (on Windows 11 first "Show more options") or "Send to → PDF-Stift" PC
- Print from Word, Chrome or Outlook to the "PDF-Stift" printer; set it up once with File → Set up as printer PC
- Watched folder: everything put there is added automatically (File → Settings; PC).
- Recently opened: right-click the PDF-Stift icon in the taskbar PC

Writing and Marking Up

Pen, highlighter, text highlighting, shapes, text box, lasso and eraser are in the tool bar and on the ribbon under "Start" and "Drawing". Notes are saved immediately – right in the library folder on your PC.

Straighten shapes: next to the pen widths there is a switch (also under Tools in the menu). When it is on, circles, boxes, triangles, diamonds, lines and arrows you draw are cleaned up at once – on your device, without AI. An arrowhead can also be a second stroke. Handwriting stays handwriting; Ctrl + Z brings back your original stroke.

V	Select text
H	Hand (move)
P	Pen
M	Highlighter (free)
U	Highlight text
T	Text box
E	Eraser
Hold the space bar	temporarily the hand; the middle mouse button as well
Ctrl + Z / Ctrl + Y	Undo / Redo

The keys work on the PC. Right-clicking selected text offers highlight, underline, strike-through and copy.

Comments

- Choose the "Comment" tool, tap the page, write, and choose "Done".
- Tap a note to read, change or delete it.
- All comments as a list: the "Comments" button at the top PC
- When you save or share, they become real PDF comments that other PDF programs show as well.

View and Navigation

Ctrl + 0	fit page
Ctrl + 1	actual size (100 %)
Ctrl + 2	fit width
Ctrl + Plus / Ctrl + Minus	zoom in / zoom out
Ctrl + Shift + R / Ctrl + Shift + L	rotate the view right / left (the PDF itself is unchanged)
Ctrl + Shift + D	two documents side by side
Ctrl + H	hide toolbars
F11	full screen
Ctrl + Tab / Ctrl + W	next tab / close tab
Home, Page Up, Page Down, End	first, previous, next, last page

Single pages, two pages side by side and "cover page alone" are on the ribbon under "View". The "Pages" button shows the thumbnails.

Searching

- In the open PDF: Ctrl + F, next with F3, previous with Shift + F3.
- In all PDFs: the search field in the library searches the full text.
- Starred: tap the star on a page; the pages then appear in the library under "Starred".

Scans and Text Recognition

- Scans are made searchable automatically – in the background while you keep working.
- The "OCR" indicator at the top right: gray = ready, flickering = recognizing, empty circle = automatic recognition off. Tap it to see the progress, to pause, to switch automatic recognition on or off, or to recognize the current PDF now.
- Clean up scans (Tools): straighten skewed pages, remove blank pages, increase contrast.
- In the Windows app the text recognition built into Windows does the work – much faster.

Notebook

In the notebook you write on pages with unlimited space, organized in notebooks and sections.

- Copy slides with your notes: Tools → "Copy to notebook", or drag slides from the page sidebar onto the notebook page.
- Insert templates: Cornell, meeting, lecture.
- Add text snippets such as "Important!" or "Definition" and slide markers from the tools sidebar.
- Link notebook pages and PDFs in both directions; "What links here?" shows the other direction.
- Restore earlier versions; save or print a notebook page as PDF (split onto several pages).

Two Documents Side by Side

Press Ctrl + Shift + D or use the button in the toolbar to open a second area on the right. There you choose a PDF from the library or a notebook page. Both sides share the same bars; you can drag slides from the page sidebar on the left onto the notebook page on the right. The double arrow in the right area swaps the sides.

Presentations

Creating and Importing from PowerPoint

- Library → Presentations → **New presentation** or **Open PowerPoint** (one or more .pptx files).
- Import a whole folder: the menu (three dots) on the "Open PowerPoint" card → "Import whole folder"; in the Windows app also File → "Import folder of PowerPoint files". A list shows what was imported.
- Text (with custom bullets, indents and paragraph spacing), shapes, pictures, tables, charts (also stacked and with lines over columns), SmartArt graphics, equations, gradients, animations, transitions and embedded videos and sounds are imported – click the play button to play them.
- A slide does not look quite like in PowerPoint? Right-click the slide in the slide list → **Take slide as picture from PowerPoint**. It then looks exactly like the original but can no longer be edited (undo: Ctrl + Z). Works for presentations imported with version 1.87 or later.

Editing, Presenting and Saving

- Edit as in PowerPoint: slides and layouts, design, text boxes, shapes, pictures, tables and charts; animations on the "Animations" tab.

- **Drawing on slides**: **Drawing** tab → pen, highlighter or eraser (or the same tools in the toolbar) – you write straight onto the slide, as in PDFs. “Select” or Esc switches back to editing. The strokes are kept when saving as PDF and as PowerPoint; ink from PowerPoint files is imported. With a stylus the line gets thinner or thicker depending on pressure. The **eraser** removes either just the touched parts or whole strokes; with the **lasso** you circle strokes and then move them, drag the corners to resize, recolor or delete them.
- **Sketch → Slide** (green button next to “New slide”, Ctrl + Shift + M): draw right on the slide. Circles, rectangles, triangles, lines and arrows are straightened as you draw – without AI and at no cost (switch off with “Shapes instantly”; Ctrl + Z brings back your original stroke). You can also add an arrowhead to a line as a second stroke. **Clean up** uses the AI to convert only what you just drew on this slide – handwriting, tables, charts, formulas – in place and matching what is already on the slide; text written inside a drawn box ends up in the box. This needs your own API key (File → Settings → Sketch → Slide). Esc or “Close” ends drawing.
- **Templates (slide master)**: under “Open PowerPoint” choose ⋯ → **Import as template** and pick your organization’s PowerPoint template. From then on “New presentation” offers it: background, logo, footer and fonts come from the template, and “New slide” lists its layouts. An existing presentation gets the look via Design → **Apply template**. Footer text, slide number and the bottom-right field: Insert → Footer.
- **Equations**: Insert → **Equation** or any button on the **Equation** tab (also on PDF pages), then type right in place. The tab has structures (fraction, superscript, root, sum, integral …), symbols, templates such as net present value, colour, size and LaTeX. While typing, / makes a fraction, ^ a superscript, _ a subscript. Done: click elsewhere or “Done”; double-click edits the equation again.
- **Calculation steps**: press Enter inside an equation – a new line appears and all “=” signs line up. With an animation (“Animations” tab, “By paragraph”) the steps appear line by line when presenting.
- **Equations in text**: while typing in a text box, choose a button on the “Equation” tab – the equation sits right in the sentence. Equations from Word can simply be pasted (Ctrl + V); equations in PowerPoint files stay editable.
- Own templates: “Equation” tab → **Template** → “Save current equation as template”. **Shortcuts** lists abbreviations such as <= for ≤ or -> for →.

- Present: F5 from the beginning, Shift + F5 from the current slide; the presenter view shows the next slide, a timer and your notes.
- Save as PDF or back as a PowerPoint file – animations, indents, bullet colours, charts and equations (still editable in PowerPoint) are kept.

Presenting PDFs

- Presentation with laser pointer: Ctrl + L; with presenter view: Ctrl + Shift + P.

Tools

The “Tools” button at the top opens the overview of all tools; the tools sidebar can be searched as well.

- Create PDF, combine, organize pages (rotate, delete, move, extract, split).
- Edit text, edit images, export (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, images).
- Header and footer, page numbers, watermark, bookmarks, stamps.
- Handouts with 2–9 slides per page, with note lines if you like (as a new PDF in the same folder).
- Compare with an earlier version or another PDF.
- Fill and sign, prepare forms, protect with a password.

Redacting

- Redact: drag over areas and choose “Apply redaction” – the content underneath is removed for good.
- Find and redact: enter names or let PDF-Stift find them (e-mail, phone, IBAN, student ID, date), check, apply.
- Old, unredacted versions are deleted (can be switched off in the settings).

Saving and Sharing

- Save the PDF with notes: Ctrl + S opens “Save as” PC
- Drag out: drag a tab or a PDF from the library to the desktop, into a folder or into an Outlook e-mail – with notes PC
- Print: Ctrl + P.
- View and restore earlier versions: Tools → Compare → “With an earlier version”.

Settings

File → Settings or Ctrl + , . There you find page display, start tool, print quality, automatic text recognition, redaction, earlier versions, target folder, watched folder, language and the library folder (Settings → Library).

Updates and Backup

- “Update available” (blue) appears as soon as a new version is out on GitHub – click it and choose “Install”. To check yourself: Help → Check for updates.
- Backup: your PDFs are ordinary files in the library folder. Back up this folder with your usual backup (Help → Open library folder).

Help and Feedback

- This quick guide: Help → Quick guide, F1 or the “?” button at the top right. It appears as a column to the right of the document, can be searched, and is hidden again with the same button. English or German: at the top of the column or under Settings → Quick guide.
- At start the quick guide opens as a PDF in the first tab (folder “Help” of the library). To switch this off: Settings → “Open the quick guide as the first document at start”.
- Version numbers: Help → About PDF-Stift.
- Bugs and wishes: as an issue on the project page on GitHub (Help → Project page on GitHub).